

THE COMMUNITY ARISES, GROWS, MATURES, AND DIES

CLIMAX COMMUNITY

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Frederic Clements (1874–1945)

BEFORE

1872 German botanist August Grisebach classifies the world's vegetation patterns in relation to climate.

1874 British philosopher Herbert Spencer suggests that the human population can be thought of as a giant organism.

1899 In the US, Henry Cowles proposes that vegetation develops in stages, a process called succession.

AFTER

1926 US ecologist Henry Gleason argues that a climax community is a coincidental collection of individuals.

1939 British botanist Arthur Tansley suggests there is not a single climax community but "polyclimaxes" responding to various factors.

The term "climax community" was first proposed in 1916 by American botanist Frederic Clements. He used it to describe an enduring ecological community that has reached a steady state, such as a naturally stable forest